

My Week of Potatoes

By Andrew McGallian

10/18/24: Glacier Gold's

The week began with **hashbrowns**—crispy and golden, **Glacier Gold's** finest,
from a bag purchased at Jewel Osco.

Their packaging boasts "*grown and processed in the **USA**,*"
but the details remain obscure.

Washington is listed as the company's base,
but these potatoes might have emerged from **Idaho's** dark soils,
known as the *potato heartland*.

A crop shaped by earth and climate,
harvested by unseen hands,
moved through distribution channels,
and factories before it reached my breakfast plate.

*The journey of these **hashbrowns** is hidden* from me,
shielded by the freezer section
and the convenience of modern life.

I consume them without thought,
but they carry a quiet history—
a lineage that spans soil, trucks,
and factory belts before sizzling in my air fryer.

10/19/24 – 10/20/24: The Days Without

Some days,
I don't touch **potatoes**, *at all*.

I barely think about them.

They rest,
waiting in storage,
silently continuing their path
without me.

10/21/24: Routinely Discarded

Another breakfast of **Glacier Gold's hashbrowns**, identical to Friday's.

Their texture on my tongue is now familiar, *habitual*.

I pull them from their processed form to something warm and edible.

The *routine blurs* their origin—

does each bite taste of earth,

or is it shaped more by the industrial hand?

Later, I push down a **bag of potato chips** in the *trash*,

discarded after a game of cards.

*I never touched the **chips** themselves,*

only the **crinkled bag** as I tamped it down.

This fleeting contact reminds me

of the half-seen products

that move through my life—

part of my *consumption*,

yet distant from my *awareness*.

10/22/24: The Ubiquity

The day of potato abundance.

It begins, as usual, with **Glacier Gold hashbrowns**,

and then evolves into something richer—

a lunch at **Valois** with a side of **fries**,

while my girlfriend enjoys a plate of their **hashbrowns**.

Sysco trucks deliver food to this diner

that seems untouched by time.

Later, I grab a bag of **Lays Classic Baked chips**.

The quiet crunch fills the silence of my study,

but it's only later that I think—

where do **Lays** find their **potatoes**?

This familiar yellow bag is a product of *industrial scale*,

potatoes harvested en masse,

processed beyond recognition,

shipped to a campus market.

I consume them mindlessly,
their journey obliterated by convenience.

At **Jewel Osco**,
I grab a small **bag of red potatoes**.

They're not for immediate consumption—
just a future meal I'll cook
when I have *time*.

Their rough skins
tell of a more intimate connection to the land.
I don't know which soil *nurtured* them,
but their *organic form* feels closer to nature
than the processed **hashbrowns**
and **chips** that have dominated my week.

10/23/24: The Growing Gap

Another breakfast, another serving
of **Glacier Gold's hashbrowns**.

My routine has become a *loop*,
the **hashbrowns** comforting in their predictability.

But this time, I notice the growing gap
between the origin of these frozen potatoes
and the story I'm telling myself.

What do I really know about them?

At lunch, my girlfriend picks
at **Miss Vickie's Salt and Vinegar chips**,
part of my **sandwich** order
at **Capriotti's**.

Miss Vickie's—
the brand evokes a rustic, homemade feel,
but is that just *clever marketing*?

These **chips**,
with their *artisanal allure*,
have traveled far too,
though their exact path
remains hidden
behind packaging and distribution chains.

I wonder again—
where are these **potatoes** grown,
and *what distance have they traveled*
to meet my touch?

The Journey

The **potato** has been my quiet companion this week,
appearing in many *forms*—
***frozen hashbrowns, diner fries,**
industrial chips,
and **fresh red potatoes.**

Each form represents a different point
on the journey *from soil to my body,*
from fresh to processed,
from farm to freezer.

Yet, despite their constant presence,
their origins remain elusive.

How did they travel?
Who grew them?
What lands shaped their flavor?

The **hashbrowns**, *frozen and convenient,*
hide the story of labor and land
behind the chill of the freezer aisle.

The **fries** at **Valois**,
though *warm and nostalgic,*
are part of the larger **Sysco** machine,
a web of suppliers delivering
mass-produced food.

The **chips**—whether from **Lays** or **Miss Vickie's**—
arrive as *polished products of industry,*
far removed
from the potato fields they were *born* in.

The small **bag of red potatoes** feels like
the closest connection to the earth I've had this week.

I can imagine them growing under the surface,
pulled from the soil by **human hands.**

Yet, even their story is incomplete—

another mystery

wrapped in my *consumption*.

In the end, the **potato** is everywhere,

but its journey is often invisible.

As I eat, I participate in a system

that spans continents and industries,

yet leaves me disconnected from the land,

labor, and resources

that bring these humble tubers to my plate.